## OFF THE TRACKS

- **Gujarat's malnutrition problem persists despite multiple schemes, campaigns, budgetary allocations**
- **SDG report says nearly 40% children under five are underweight or stunted, 62.5% pregnant women anaemic**
- **Big shortage of anganwadis, which provide critical services, in the tribal and rural areas**

And this is despite an array of schemes and budgetary allocations. The NITI Aayog's Sustainable Development Goals (SDG) India Index 2023-24, released in July 2024, said that nearly 40 per cent of children in Gujarat under five are underweight or stunted, and over 38 per cent of the population is undernourished. The state also lags behind many peers in addressing the issue of hunger. Gujarat's performance is concerning as its SDG-2 score has dropped from 49 in 2018 to 41 in 2019, and now stabilised at 46 in 2023-24, suggesting limited progress in tackling malnutrition.

"Tribal areas are the worst affected due to landscape and distance," says social activist Neeta Hardikar, whose NGO Anandi has been working in the tribal regions of Gujarat to spread awareness about health, education and women's empowerment. "In aspirational districts like Dahod, AWC numbers have not increased. But the biggest concern is the staff. Just two people per anganwadi is too little. Workers are stretched thin and unable to give quality attention to women and children."

The SDG Index also notes that 62.5 per cent of pregnant women aged 15-49 in Gujarat are anaemic, contributing to intergenerational malnutrition cycles. "Intergenerational malnutrition requires persistent intervention. Initial findings of a recent study we did on food security across 30 households of each village in five talukas of Dahod district revealed that only two of the five food types prescribed for a nutritive diet show up on their plate on an average day," says Hardikar. "Allocated ration is not enough and does not reach intended beneficiaries."

In the past four months, the Bhupendra Patel government has announced two new initiatives to counter malnutrition—the Mukhyamantri Paushtik Alpahar Yojana to provide protein-rich snacks to students in state-run and grant-in-aid schools with budgetary funds of Rs 607 crore annually; and the Nutrition Mission, with an allocation of Rs 75 crore to enhance obstetric and newborn care. The MoWCD submitted in the Lok Sabha in December 2024 that the proportion of stunted children in Gujarat dropped from 53.6 per cent in 2022 to 40.8 per cent in 2024; the share of underweight children fell from 23.1 to 21 per cent over the same period.

Yet, there is a long way to go. Hardikar says schemes and allocations don't translate into results on the ground. "Anganwadi workers are not trained for the complex job at hand. Understanding around contraception is still abysmally low. Child and maternal mortality from malnutrition is under-reported as the anganwadi and ASHA workers are in denial. Any discussion on the issue at the gram sabhas is only to demand explanations; we need constructive feedback sessions rather than a punitive process," she says. "Keeping up the morale of the anganwadi and ASHA workers is critical here." ■

ANDHRA PRADESH



ANI

# NAIDU'S POVERTY PANACEA

**By Amarnath K. Menon**

Ugadi, the Telugu New Year, is regarded as an auspicious time for new beginnings. And that's the day Andhra Pradesh chief minister N. Chandrababu Naidu chose to unveil an ambitious plan—part of his Swarna Andhra 2047 vision—which he claims could redefine poverty alleviation. The Zero Poverty-P4 initiative, launched on March 30, is a bold experiment in inclusive growth, enlisting the wealthiest 10 per cent of the population to support the bottom 20 per cent. The goal is sweeping: a poverty-free Andhra Pradesh by 2029.

At the heart of P4—short for Public-Private-People Partnership—is a structured mentorship programme. Affluent individuals, called 'Margadarsis' (mentors), will be encouraged to "adopt" underprivileged families, designated as 'Bangaru Kutumbams' (golden families). These partnerships, facilitated by the government, go beyond financial aid. Margadarsis—expected to be from among the